

vegetables. This preference to preserve the basics is reflected in everything he does in life. "I like things that have the element of the base that it is carrying. Covering anything with superficiality is a big turnoff for me," he explains.

Thanks to the work schedule at Ideaforge, he has now become more practical in what he eats. Though he relies on eating one-pot meals, he also finds himself ordering burgers and rolls often. Rahul loves eating Asian and European cuisines including rice and vegetables that are cooked together in the same pot using as minimal spices as possible.

Wind in his hair

Rahul had always been very passionate about biking. In fact, his love for cycling goes back to his school days. He recalls cycling at high speeds and using speed breakers as platforms to launch cycles in the air in his childhood days to showcase his expertise. He bought an Enfield 500 bike during his college days in Bombay, and made several modifications to it himself.

"Speed continues to give me the kick. My first bike ride was on my brother's bike. I was not supposed to ride it fast, but I kept on testing the limit of the bike every now and then and ended up meeting with a few accidents," he says.

"I tweaked the Bullet 500 I bought and played around with it. I tweaked the bike to make it deliver more power than it was originally meant to produce," shares Rahul.

Rahul is still a bike person at heart. However, he now drives a car and plans to buy a Ducati Scrambler one day (of course after the permission of his family).

Apart from the love for speed and tech, Neha Chauhan, his wife, is the real love of his life. A romantic at heart, Rahul got married to Neha in a destination wedding in Goa. It was just before the lockdown that the wedding took place. Rahul recalls, if not for the last-moment opportunity they got, the wedding would have been a Zoom event! The couple invited all their friends from school and college life, and Rahul says it was a dream wedding for the couple. Neha is an actress and has featured in several roles on the big and small screens.

And on how the duo met, Rahul answers, "We just bumped into each



Rahul with his co-founders and one of their drones

other one day and became the best of friends before expressing love for each other and getting married finally in Goa!"

Relating life with football

Rahul, who heads the technical teams at one of the most promising startups of India today, used to be a part of his college football team. He feels that being goalkeeper on the football team has helped him shape his professional as well as physical life.

"I have learned a lot of life lessons from the point of view of a goalkeeper. I see the work and collaborations that we do at Ideaforge as a football team analogy where different people have different roles, similar to positions you play in football," he explains.

Explaining the difference between a goalkeeper and a striker in a football team he says, "A striker has to keep trying and convert two successes out of ten attempts. A goalkeeper on the other hand has to keep saving, and two failures out of ten attempts is a catastrophic failure."

Each member of the team, as he learned while playing football, needs to understand the importance of their respective roles. Moreover, each individual also needs to understand the difference in each other's roles while playing as a team.

"You may have done 90% of the things right but a small 10% error can make others complain about how your

mistake made the team lose the game. It doesn't just happen on the football field, it happens in real and professional life too," he explains.

He adds, "Understanding and cherishing one's role is the key to success on and off the field. Football has had that influence on me about things that surround me." When asked if he relates his co-founders (Ideaforge team) to the football analogy he says,

"Ankit as CEO has been taking care of the business and customers, which means looking into sales and funding as well. His role has been that of a striker in the football team and that of the team manager. Vipul and I have had transitions of roles and we both have been goalkeepers here at Ideaforge. Ashish, who is already at the midfield, helps us in setting up the game. Mine and Ashish's midfield roles include feeding the strikers with the right thing to go forward and score."

Rahul's favourite footballer happens to be German goalkeeper and captain Oliver Kahn. Rahul is also an ardent fan of the Formula 1 races. He used to dedicate his Sundays to the races, including pre- and post-race briefings, and everything else around the fast machines.

Anything for a friend

How much importance Rahul gives to his friends is evident from the Ideaforge team, where on more than one occasion he has proved what friendship really